even sure why the murder happened and worked on the ‘accepted theory, which is probably correct, . . . that the murder was a direct act of revenge for death of Lajpat Rai’. All they could say was that, ‘against some of those arrested there was secret information of complicity, while a number of others have been indulging in inflammatory speeches ever since his death’. Remarkably, this was being maintained while the authorities were clear that, ‘in no case, however, was there anything material enough to justify further detention’. All that they could say was that the ‘Punjab Government are meantime sparing no effort’.

Although optimism was expressed in the statement that ‘there are several eye-witnesses who profess ability to identify one or more of the murderers’, the blunt truth was that at that stage no eyewitness could identify anyone. All that they could say with reasonable confidence was that, ‘it is also reasonably certain that carefully chosen line of retreat through D.A.V College compound required intimate local knowledge in the part of one or more of the culprits’, but they were speculating when they declared that they ‘were probably seen by large number of students’. In fact, it was even more speculative for the viceroy to assert that ‘fired cartridge cases are also thought to bear sufficiently distinctive marks to lead to the identification of firearms used if they are recovered’, because almost a month after the assassination the authorities still had no recovered cartridges. Such was the extent of pure conjecture as to who the assailants were and how they worked that the viceroy even wondered out loud in his telegram, that the ‘possibility of outside persons having been imported is being carefully examined, and every other likely line of enquiry is being actively followed up’.[14]